Massachusetts Association of Behavioral Health Systems

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Bournewood Hospital
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June 13, 2025

Center for Medicare and Medicaid Services
Re: Docket (CMS-2025-0050) Digital Health RFI

On behalf of the Massachusetts Association of Behavioral Health Systems (MABHS), a statewide organization of 53 Psychiatric and Substance Use facilities, we are offering these comments for your consideration relative to Docket (CMS-2025-0050) Digital Health RFI. These comments are focused on our request for CMS to reinstate remote virtual services for Partial Hospital Programs (PHP)

Many of our hospitals offer Partial Hospital services, and during the Public Health Emergency, our patients benefitted enormously through Medicare's coverage of virtual PHP services. Unfortunately, Medicare members are not currently afforded the same virtual treatment options as non-Medicare members, unless they are able to pay out of pocket.

We urge CMS to reinstate virtual PHP services for Medicare beneficiaries for the following reasons:

- Virtual PHP achieves similar clinically equivalent outcomes such as reduction in symptoms, improved functioning, and participant satisfaction as in-person care;

- Virtual PHP improves attendance and reduces barriers such as transportation, caregiving responsibilities, disability barriers such as for wheelchair bound patients, and access despite geographic distance or rural isolation;

- Virtual PHP is beneficial for those who suffer from disabilities and chronic medical conditions that make in-person attendance extremely difficult. Additionally, those who may have a contagious illness can participate in virtual PHP without jeopardizing others;

- Virtual PHP is beneficial to workforce retention for staff who are at risk of leaving the field due to health concerns, caregiving responsibilities, or geographic constraints;

- Finally, Virtual PHP is beneficial to maintaining continuity of care for discharged patients following a psychiatric hospitalization, thereby helping to reduce more costly inpatient re-admissions.

We respectfully request that CMS consider reinstating **Virtual PHP** for the benefit of Medicare members. This population would benefit greatly by having this option where in-person programming is not feasible or preferred. Please let me know if you have any questions or need any further information. Thank you for your consideration,

Sincerely,

David Matteodo, Executive Director
Massachusetts Association of Behavioral Health Systems